The Tabernacle: God Moves In

Exodus 25–31; 35–40

> **The big idea:** At Sinai God told Israel to build him a tent so he could live in the middle of their camp. Every piece of it, from the one gate to the mercy seat, points to Jesus, the Word who pitched his tent among us and opened the way to God.

Before you meet: Read

Exodus 25:1–22 | Exodus 28:29–38 | Exodus 40:33–38 | John 1:14 | Hebrews 10:19–22

Open (5 minutes)

Think of a home where you always felt welcome. What made it feel that way?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"And let them make me a _____, that I may _____ in their midst." *(Exodus 25:8)*

The craftsmen told Moses, "The people bring much more than _____," so Moses told everyone to stop giving. *(Exodus 36:5–7)*

Of Bezalel the artist, God said, "I have filled him with the _____ of God, with ability and intelligence." *(Exodus 31:3)*

"There I will _____ with you, and from above the _____ seat, from between the two cherubim that are on the ark of the testimony, I will speak with you." *(Exodus 25:22)*

"So Aaron shall bear the names of the sons of Israel in the breastpiece of judgment on his _____, when he goes into the Holy Place." *(Exodus 28:29)*

"Then the cloud covered the tent of meeting, and the _____ of the LORD filled the tabernacle." *(Exodus 40:34)*

Discuss

1. Exodus spends thirteen chapters on a tent, more than it spends on the flood or on creation. Why do you think God cared so much about the details of his dwelling place? *Exodus 25:8–9, 40*

2. The people gave so much that Moses had to tell them to stop. What makes a person give like that? *Exodus 36:5–7*

3. Walk through the tent from the gate to the ark: one gate, the altar, the basin, the veil, the mercy seat. What does that order teach about coming to God? *Exodus 27:1–2; 30:17–21; 26:31–33*

4. Inside the ark was the law Israel would break. Over it was the mercy seat, and over that was God's presence. What does that picture say to you? *Exodus 25:16–22*

5. Moses prayed, "If your presence will not go with me, do not bring us up from here." What would you be tempted to settle for without God? *Exodus 33:14–16*

6. Christians together are now God's temple, and each believer's body is a temple of the Spirit. How should that change the way you treat your church, other believers, and your own body? *1 Corinthians 3:16; 6:19*

Apply this week

Read Exodus 25:1–22 and 40:16–38 this week. Trace the floor plan in the full lesson from the gate to the ark, and name how each piece points to Jesus. Then spend ten minutes in prayer with Hebrews 4:16 open, and pray Moses' prayer over one hard thing in your week: "If your presence will not go with me, do not bring us up from here" (Exodus 33:15).

Memory verse

"And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory."

John 1:14

Pray

Thank God that he wants to live with his people, and that in Jesus he came to live among us. Thank Jesus that he carries your name before the Father. Ask for confidence to draw near to God because the veil has been torn.

LEADER NOTES · LESSON 10

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Session plan (about 70 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Exodus 25:1–22 aloud, then 40:33–38. Close with John 1:14.
10 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
30 min	Discuss: choose 4 of the 6 questions. Questions 3, 4, and 6 matter most.
5 min	Walk the group through the floor plan in the full lesson, from the gate to the ark, naming how each piece points to Christ.
10 min	Apply and pray. Introduce the memory verse and the reading for Lesson 11 (Leviticus 1, 16, and Hebrews 9:11–10:18).

Main points to land

1. The tabernacle was God's house, his dwelling place (mishkan) in the center of the camp. It is a big step toward the goal of the whole story since Eden: God living with his people (Exodus 25:8).
2. God gave the pattern, the people gave willingly, and the Spirit gave Bezalel his skill. Grace turns freed slaves into generous givers and beauty into worship (Exodus 31:3; 36:5–7).
3. The layout teaches the way to God: one gate, the altar of sacrifice first, washing, then a veil guarded by cherubim. In the inner room the mercy seat covered the law Israel could not keep (Exodus 25:16–22).
4. Sinners needed a mediator. The high priest carried Israel's names on his heart and wore Holy to the LORD on his turban so the people would be accepted (Exodus 28:29, 36–38).
5. The glory filled the tent, and later the Word became flesh and pitched his tent among us. Jesus is the door, the sacrifice, the light, the bread, and the High Priest who tore the veil open, and by his Spirit his people are now God's temple (John 1:14; Hebrews 10:19–22).

Answer key (Observe)

1. sanctuary; dwell
2. enough
3. Spirit
4. meet; mercy
5. heart
6. glory

Questions people will ask

Does every peg and color of the tabernacle have a hidden meaning?
Hebrews calls the tent a copy and shadow of the heavenly things (8:5), and it explains the big pieces: the veil, the high priest, the blood, the Most Holy Place. Some readers have found a symbol in every hook, which goes beyond what Scripture says. The details mattered because God gave them, but the meaning lives in the main pieces and their order. Keep the group on the way to God through Christ.

Where did a nation of former slaves get all that gold?
From Egypt. As Israel left, the Egyptians gave them silver, gold, and clothing (Exodus 12:35–36). The wealth of their captors became the material for God's house, freely given back to him.

What happened to the ark of the covenant?
The Bible does not say. It most likely disappeared when Babylon destroyed Jerusalem in 586 BC, and it was never in the second temple. Jeremiah even said a day would come when no one would miss it or make another (Jeremiah 3:16). We do not need it, because Christ is the true mercy seat (Romans 3:25).

When Paul says "you are God's temple," does he mean my body?
In 1 Corinthians 3:16 the "you" is plural: the church together is God's temple, so dividing or harming the church is serious. In 1 Corinthians 6:19 Paul does speak of each believer's body as a temple of the Holy Spirit. Both are true, and the first is easy to miss.

Closing prayer

Father, thank you that you did not stay far away on the mountain, but came down to live among your people. Thank you for Jesus, the Word made flesh, our door, our sacrifice, and our High Priest, who carries our names on his heart. Give each person here confidence to come near to you through him, and make us together a dwelling place for you by your Spirit. Amen.